

NOSTALGIA DONE RIGHT

The Last Of Us HBO series recreates the magic of the PS3 game for new fans and old

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IF

there's one thing about adaptations that we're swearing by of late, especially

after the Rings Of Power shenanigans fresh in our mind, is to not have sky high expectations of any adapted-to-cinema version of seminal books or video games we've especially enjoyed over the years and hold near and dear to our hearts. This was pretty much our state of mind when all The Last Of Us teasers started hitting online — don't be too excited, watch it because it needs to be watched, ultimately don't be mad if the HBO show doesn't hold a candle to the brilliance that was the original PS3 game, which deservedly ended up winning SKOAR!'s GotY circa 2013. Boy, were we wrong about our skepticism!

Let's be clear, at the time of writing this, we've only seen the first three episodes of the televised HBO series (which has a total of 10 episodes), but it's enough to form an early opinion on the show's authenticity towards the source material – the original PS3

game, in this case. And we are just short of ecstatic on everything that we've seen, heard and felt so far on HBO's adaptation of The Last Of Us.

When The Last Of Us released on PS3 roughly a decade ago, the game's top-notch art direction with a variety of breathtaking environments immediately caught every player's attention. It's great to see the show-runners capture the overall post-apocalyptic aesthetic and vibe of the game, staying as close to the source material and transporting viewers into the world effortlessly. The show's art department deserves a lot of credit for bringing the game's world alive in every single little detail – from the crumbling ruins of Boston city to infected clickers amidst death and destruction to FEDRA soldiers inside quarantine zones, and everything in between.

Apart from triggering just the right sound byte for any given moment, the game also has one of the most haunting soundtracks we have experienced in a video game, which complements the visuals and heightens the mood appropriately with the right

soundscape. We're happy to report that the HBO series stays true to this very important element of the game, reprising Gustavo Santaolalla's sensational original game score most prominently during the opening credits of each episode. The subtle notes of the melancholic guitar score has a way of immersing you into the world and heightening your overall emotional experience like nothing else. It's haunting, sad, contemplative and just right for Joel and Ellie's saga.

Set in a post-apocalyptic world ravaged by 'clickers', The Last of Us is unlike any other zombie survival game you'll play, with cleverly interwoven elements of stealth and action – yes, it's far from a hack-n-slash tour de force. Played in third-person, it gives you plenty of freedom to tackle situations the way you want and engage enemy hordes on your own terms – through stealth and cover mechanics, a variety of weapons, by laying traps, creating distractions, melee combat, etc. Some of these gameplay elements – like Joel's rifle, Ellie's sidearm, their shoulder-strapped torches – are all faithfully